

Effects of ADHD on College Students: A Surveyed Study

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Research Subject Area

(a.) My research subject area is Attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) in young adults. (b.) This topic is important as understanding the effects of ADHD is crucial to helping them succeed. Neurodivergent people need assistance in many components of their lives to match their neurotypical peers. By reaching out and learning about how ADHD impacts people's lives, we can do more research into perfecting strategies to assist them. (c.) My research is specifically on how ADHD affects various aspects of their lives, from school to health to work and their connections to people.

Research Questions

(a.) This research aims to study young adults and understand how ADHD will differentiate them from their peers. (b.) My research question is, "What are the effects of ADHD on the life of college students?" (c.) I hypothesize that if a college student has ADHD, they may have different experiences in various aspects of college than their neurotypical peers. (d.) My independent variables would be ADHD in adults, specifically college students, and whether they have it. (e.) The dependent variable would be various aspects of college life: grades, friendships, relationships, living arrangements/conditions, mental health, physical health, diet, and extracurriculars.

Literature Review

(a.) *Assessment of learning and memory impairments in adults with predominantly inattentive versus combined presentation attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder* (Phillips et al., 2023) is a cross-sectional study on the differences between adults, mostly college students, with and without ADHD and how they perform on a Rey Auditory Verbal Learn Test (RAVLT) and the Visuospatial Memory Test-Revised (BVMT-R). (b.) The study captures two types of ADHD:

Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder-Inattentive (ADHD-I) and Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder-Combined (ADHD-C). The test also has 380 participants: 155 with ADHD-I, 165 with ADHD-C, and a group without ADHD who may be diagnosed with depression or anxiety or with no diagnosis. The study showed that those with ADHD performed worse in verbal learning, visual learning, and recalling information. Similarly to this study, I would like to identify what areas people with ADHD struggle with compared to those without it. I am also using college-aged students to do my study as well. Some things I will do differently are my methodology, as I will be doing a survey instead of testing; my criteria, as the survey does not test the variants of ADHD; and the age group will be only college students instead of mostly college students,

(a.) *A new organizational and study skills intervention for college students with ADHD* (Hartung et al., 2022) is a study on how cognitive behavioral treatment (CBT) can help undergraduate, post-baccalaureate, and graduate students improve their organizational, time management, and planning (OTMP) skills. (b.) The study used CBT with additional support in psychoeducation on ADHD and medication management. Participants were brought in for 6 group therapy sessions and two individual sessions. The overall analysis reported improvements in inattentiveness, ADHD symptoms, various types of impairment, and OTMP skills. Similarly to this study, I would like to assess students with ADHD and their symptoms and difficulties. However, unlike this study, I will only be assessing college students. It will only be a survey to gather information instead of psychological interventions like CBT to improve the participants' skills.

(a.) *Predicting impairment in college students with ADHD: The role of executive functions* (Dvorsky & Langberg, 2014) is a longitudinal study on if the executive function (EF)

ratings done by college students and their parents would predict the overall function of the student. (b.) The study started at the beginning of the school year to get original EF ratings from the students and parents and then occurred again at the end of the year to see if the predictions from the original ratings matched. The study used 59 college students with ADHD and their parents. The study found that the original EF ratings did tend to predict the relationship between ADHD and the symptoms of the students and how they were able to handle academic and college life. Like this study, I also aim to analyze how college students feel about their ADHD symptoms and how they impact them in various aspects of college. However, I will not be assessing parents, the survey will only be sent out once, and it assesses symptoms other than EF.

(a.) *Self-monitoring by college students with ADHD: The impact on academic performance* (Scheithauer & Kelley, 2014) is a study on how interventions around self-monitoring may improve the academic performance of college students with ADHD. (b.) The study recruited 53 students, but only 41 completed it. The participants were randomly assigned group sessions that either taught them self-monitoring, study skills and goal setting (SM+ group) or only study skills and goal setting (SM- group). The results showed that the SM+ group significantly improved their ADHD symptoms and academic life. However, the SM- group did not find any significant improvements in these areas, showing that self-monitoring may help students with ADHD. Like this study, I will be using college students and assessing their handling of college with ADHD. However, unlike this, I will not monitor the group and teach them any skills as I will only collect self-reported information.

Ethical Considerations

My study is meant to be as ethical and safe as possible. (a.) Within The College of New Jersey Institutional Review Board (IRB), the “Belmont Report” (National Commission for the

Protection of Human Subjects of Biomedical and Behavioral Research, 1976) is used for ethics. Within this report, selection of subjects are concerns to analyze. I aim to promote a diverse group of participants to create a fair study with no risks to people taking it. Identifying factors such as race, class, gender, and ethnicity can impact how people perceive their symptoms and the help they receive. This also ties into recruitment since having a group without diversity will not correctly represent the varying experiences of ADHD. Though I cannot individually pick out people, sending the test to as many students' emails and recording these categories will allow underrepresented groups to be studied and analyzed within our survey.

For ethics, IRB's "Justice, Diversity, and Research Ethics Guidance" (IRB, 2021) make sure the needs of underrepresented groups are met, I would like to create a version of the survey that can be printed out for those without computers or strong internet access, a downloadable spoken version for those who are not able to see, and a translated version (primarily Spanish) for students who may not speak strong English and feel more comfortable answering in a different language. Additional requests could be made to include other languages if translators are available.

(b.) In the American Psychological Association (APA) Ethical Principles of Psychologists and Code of Conduct, concerns for my study can be found in the subsection privacy and confidentiality. In our survey, the email, name, and other identifying factors (race, class, gender, ethnicity, etc.) of the student will be studied. Still, the research will be entirely anonymous. No names or significant identifiers, such as specific and detailed stories or locations in the extra information sections of the survey, will be used when publishing data. At the beginning of the survey, we need to explain that this information will be confidential and that the recording of identifiers is only to be used in analyzing different groups. By doing this, we can make sure the

participant is aware of what they are doing and where their information is going to avoid any conflicts (American Psychological Association [APA], 2017).

Participants and Setting

(a.) Within my experiment, I would like to research young adults (18-24) with ADHD in college, as well as students without ADHD, to be able to create a comparison. For both groups, I would include a diverse group of picks on lines such as various ages within the young adult range, race, gender, sexuality, socioeconomic status, background, and more.

(b.) As this study will be a survey sent out to various students, the research setting will be wherever they decide to take the test. Preferably, they will be in a place where they feel comfortable and safe answering more personal questions. Since my assessment may be time-consuming, being somewhere they can sit for long periods without getting up and moving around would also help.

Validity and Reliability

(a.) The validity of the study is found through its methodology. The study is meant to measure how ADHD, or lack thereof, impacts the lives of college students. With this, the questions on the survey ask about various parts of life and ask the participants to answer questions about them to make an accurate assessment and comparison. Though other life factors may impact the participants' answers, the overall comparison of students with and without ADHD will still be able to be found, creating a study with validity.

(b.) The reliability of the study is dependent on several factors. The participant will take the survey online and in their chosen location. With the online aspect, consistent and strong Wi-Fi is vital to avoid losing results. Participants need to be in a place where they have a good internet connection to avoid such issues. The location can also impact the reliability of the

experiment. If a participant takes the survey in an environment with many distractions, they may not answer the questions to the best of their ability. Another factor that could impact the reliability is having areas where they can explain their answers. Though the survey offers preset answers, including a section where people explain their answers can add much extra information to sort through, making analysis more complicated than it would be without it if those answers were factored in.

Methodology

(a.) The best method to make this work would be a survey sent out to the participants. Busy college students may not want to set up an entire appointment to be studied. By having a survey, I can maximize the accessibility to the experiment and use fewer resources overall.

(b.) I would send out a self-rated survey to college students' school emails, the ones they check the most frequently during this age. Since people without ADHD will not click on a quiz talking about ADHD, making it more universal can receive more results from this group. The survey would be marketed as a way to study how students feel about their college lives. In the survey, I would have a box where you could click if you had ADHD/ADD or another coexisting mental disorder, which would help assess if their mental health is impacted by ADHD alone or other conditions, such as autism spectrum disorder (ASD), bipolar disorder (BPD), obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD), anxiety, depression, and more. I would need much insight into their lives so the survey might be longer, but I would keep organized areas of straightforward questions. I would ask questions that have a spectrum of answers, from "I agree with this statement often or all the time," "I agree with this statement sometimes," "I feel neutral about this," "I disagree with this statement sometimes," and "I disagree with this statement often or all the time." I would also add a section underneath each question for the participant to explain

their answers in more detail if they choose to. This would help get the maximum amount of information the participant is comfortable sharing.

Analyses

(a.) My study showed that students with and without ADHD answered questions differently. Within the survey, if the question asked if a student was not or would not be satisfied with an aspect of college life, people with ADHD were more likely to answer with "I agree with this statement often or all the time" or "I agree with this statement sometimes." In contrast, students without ADHD were more likely to answer with "I feel neutral about this" or "I disagree with this statement sometimes" (see Figure 1). Inversely, if the question asked if a student is or would be satisfied with an aspect of college life, people with ADHD were more likely to answer with "I disagree with this statement often or all the time," "I disagree with this statement sometimes," or "I feel neutral about this." Students with ADHD were more likely to respond to these types of questions with "I agree with this statement sometimes" or "I agree with this statement often or all the time" (see Figure 2).

(b.) This demonstrates a significant difference between students with and without ADHD. Since people with ADHD suffer from symptoms that negatively impact their ability to function, these answers are expected. Many parts of college life require overarching skills such as time management and executive function. These parts will not be as easy or popular for people with ADHD as people without it and the answers to other questions demonstrate this relationship.

Advantages

(a.) My methodology has advantages when done correctly. Using a survey is an excellent way of getting information without seeing them in person. It saves time, makes the study more accessible, and provides more privacy to the participant than interviews. (b.) My study has

advantages that could happen from it being run. My study aims to learn and gather much information from students about their experiences. Using a survey provides a way to collect data without bringing people in and interviewing them individually. People may be uncomfortable with too many questions and may only show up if it takes less time or is convenient for their schedule. Using a survey allows for comfort and accessibility to any student taking it.

(c.) With this study, we could collect information on the lives of students with ADHD/ADD and how they compare to others, similar or different. This helps to gather current information that can be utilized to make changes to accessibility resources and accommodations on and off campus.

Limitations

(a.) Some limitations from my experience include making assumptions about ADHD, how time-consuming it is, and the honesty of participants. Because so much information affects how students live, the survey can only collect data on so many factors. This leaves out the many other factors that may impact students daily. Also, since we are looking for a comparison, my study does generalize the ADHD population to a degree. The survey will also be longer due to its more in-depth nature. This means people may get bored or not want to complete a survey they have to sit and work on for a while, especially if they do not have to.

The honesty of the participants is also not guaranteed. People may feel embarrassed to be honest on specific questions and either leave out information or not tell the truth entirely, damaging our results' validity.

(b.) I will factor in the assumptions on ADHD and time consumption by adding as much flexibility in answers as possible. I want to give students a way to write as much as they are comfortable with while ensuring we can gather enough data. By adding preset answers and

allowing people to expand on their answers within the study if they please, we can factor in as much information as possible. Not only that, but people can choose to make the survey as long as they want by choosing whether or not they want to expand on their answers. In order to help with honesty, I want to ensure the participant knows our survey is anonymous and that no names or identifying information will be shown to the public.

Conclusion

(a.) The research study would positively affect the student community. The survey presents itself as a way for students to freely express their experiences and feelings to an audience who wants to listen and help them. (b.) For the next steps of my research, I would like to present these to parts of school resources, such as the Accessibility Resource Center (ARC) and the Center for Student Success (CSS), as well as administration, such as the deans of various academic departments. By explaining the struggles of students with ADHD, I would use my research to promote expanding current accommodations or creating new ones to serve this population. (c.) For future research in this field, I would suggest studying and collecting data on how different kinds of accommodations and help have positively affected students with ADHD and even other disabilities. This knowledge can help create a more accessible college and a more accessible world for those with ADHD,

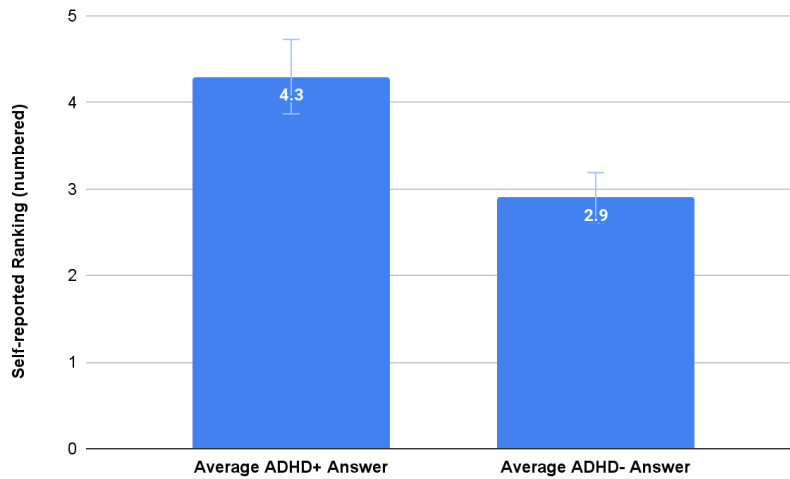
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Figures

Figure 1.

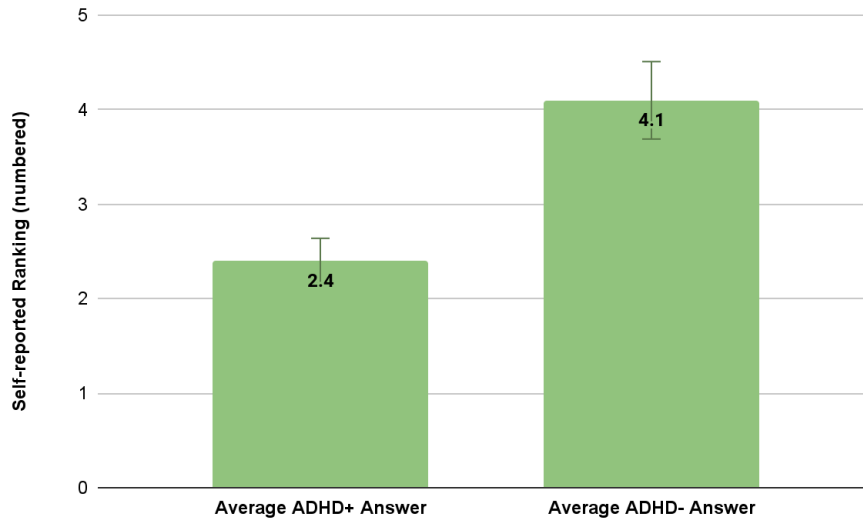
Survey Item Results: "I am not satisfied with my study skills."



Note: All answers for the study analysis were numbered. "I disagree with this statement often or all the time" was set to 1. "I disagree with this statement sometimes" was set to 2. "I feel neutral about this" was set to 3. "I agree with this statement sometimes" was set to 4. "I agree with this statement often or all the time" was set to 5. ADHD+ is the title for students with ADHD and ADHD- is the title for students without ADHD. This figure shows that the average ranking for this question for people with ADHD is 4.3. The average ranking for a student without ADHD is 2.9.

Figure 2.

Survey Item Results: "I would be or I am able to manage a leadership position in college."



Note: All answers for the study analysis were numbered. "I disagree with this statement often or all the time" was set to 1. "I disagree with this statement sometimes" was set to 2. "I feel neutral about this" was set to 3. "I agree with this statement sometimes" was set to 4. "I agree with this statement often or all the time" was set to 5. ADHD+ is the title for students with ADHD and ADHD- is the title for students without ADHD. This figure shows that the average ranking for this question for people with ADHD is 2.4. The average ranking for a student without ADHD is 4.1.